DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Who, What and How: Why Do Some Deeds Weigh More?

Daat Tevunot §125-126

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §125-126
Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Monday 1 May 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

A new section

The class began Section 6 of the English edition (page 306, from §125). The Rabbi reviewed the map so far: Section 1, introduction; Section 2, Yihud Hashem; Section 3, the time of concealment; Section 4, body and soul; Section 5, how evil is created and what it is for. Now we go into evil in more detail, in relation to man's service.

The English note at the start of the section sums up Section 5: part 1, how evil comes into existence through the absence of emanation; part 2, how it is confined within boundaries; part 3, how it becomes a source of benefit within the interconnected mechanism of forces. Now, more detail about man.

§125-126: two kinds of "bad"

The Neshamah asks (§125): until now we spoke of evil in general; explain it in more detail, and man's relationship to it.

The Sekhel answers (§126) that there are two kinds of ra:

1. **Shiflut, lowliness:** things that are degrading, shameful, base.
2. **Bitul, coming to an end:** everything physical eventually perishes. In English we might call it an imperfection rather than evil, but it is a kind of ra. Even the sun, scientists say, will one day burn out.

The second would be discussed later; the next weeks would deal with the first.

What lowliness means

Lowliness does not mean that one angel is lower than another. The angels have ten levels, as the Ramhal teaches in Derech Hashem and as the Rambam also says, yet all are holy. Lowliness means the human body and everything below it, animals and insects, which all stem from physicality, from dust.

But here is the key point. If man had stayed on his proper level, as Adam HaRishon before the sin, then even though he was made from dust, that would not be called lowliness, because

that is where he was meant to be. "That's a lesson for life," said the Rabbi. If you do the best you can, even if it is not the highest, that is good. Lowliness is when someone could have been elevated and is low instead. That is humanity today, because of the sin of Adam. We are not low because we were made from dust; we are low because we fell from where we were.

A participant observed that this can only apply to man. A pig was created as a pig, and there is no lowly pig or higher pig. Only man, who has free will, has the potential to be more. The Rabbi agreed. He also noted the Ramhal's careful wording: the lowliness of the beings below man is "not so much" of a lowliness.

Who, what and how

Before turning to Adam, the Ramhal explains what determines the effect of a human action. Because of the cog system from Section 5, every small action moves great things above and below. But not every person is the same, and not every action is the same. Two people can sit at one table, and one's actions rise to the highest levels while the other's come nowhere near.

1. Who are you? The Gemara says that when Yonatan ben Uziel sat and learned Torah, any bird flying over him was burned. Millions of others learn Torah and it never happens. The difference is who he was. A participant asked whether people are simply born on different levels. The Rabbi said no: "He wasn't born Yonatan ben Uziel. He became Yonatan ben Uziel." It is about what you have made of yourself.

2. What are you doing? Two ordinary people of the same level eat at one table. One eats his korban, a great misvah; the other eats breakfast. Same act of eating, very different effect. Further: a Kohen eating a sin offering performs a misvah, while a non-Kohen, even a great person, who eats it commits a grave sin. And Hazal say "greater is one who is commanded and does than one who is not commanded and does." Rabbi Yosef, who was blind, first thought he would be glad to hear that the blind are exempt, since his voluntary misvot would be greater. Then he heard that the commanded is greater. Being commanded puts you inside the system, so your action has far greater effect.

3. How are you doing it? The external circumstances: the preparation, the kavanah, the time. If Yonatan ben Uziel learns on Shabbat or Yom Tov, it is greater still. The Gemara says that one who is careful with the lights of Shabbat and Hanukkah will have children who are Torah scholars. Everyone lights, but some light at the right time with the right kavanah.

The great are judged more strictly

A participant connected this to the teaching that the righteous are judged "to a hair's breadth". The Rabbi agreed: because you are so high in the system, when you do wrong you affect the top, and all the cogs below are affected.

Do the commanded things first

A participant concluded that one who is not commanded is still part of the system, but on a lower level. The Rabbi agreed and added a practical lesson: focus on what you are commanded. "Problem is people like to do the things they don't need to do. They don't do the things they need to do. That's human nature."

The next class would connect this to Adam before and after the sin.

Summary

- Section 6 studies evil in relation to man; the Ramhal identifies two kinds of ra: lowliness and things coming to an end.
- Being made from dust is not lowliness if one stays on one's proper level; humanity is low because it fell through Adam's sin.
- The effect of a deed depends on who does it, what is done, and how it is done.
- One who is commanded and does is greater, because being commanded puts him inside the system.
- Greater people affect the top of the system, so they are judged more strictly; and we should put the commanded things first.

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